

CHAO FA

THE TRAIL · THE ENDINGS

WHAT BECAME OF EACH VILLAGER

16 VILLAGERS 10 ENDINGS EACH FIND BY NUMBER

This game is dedicated to all the men and women who served in the Vietnam War; to the Hmong who served and were killed; to those who died in the jungles of Laos and those who are still there; to the CIA, to General Vang Pao, and to everyone who brought attention to this tragic chapter of history.

SECOND EDITION · THE ENDINGS BOOKLET · 160 ENDINGS, 10 FOR EVERY VILLAGER, FOUND BY NUMBER
(2026)

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What this book is for

Open it when the game is over. For every villager it holds an ending for everything that can have happened to them, the same on either side of their card, each one different and each one drawn from the real-life stories of Hmong families, a countryless nation, who lived through these years. The first chapter shows how to find the right ending by its number; then come the villagers, one after another, in the order of their cards.

BEFORE YOU READ

How to find an ending

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
CROSSED THE MEKONG	CROSSED THE MEKONG	STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS	TAKEN PRISONER	KILLED BY SOLDIERS	STARVED	DIED OF SICKNESS	KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE	DROWNED IN THE MEKONG	SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Every villager in Chao Fa has an ending for everything that can happen to them: crossing the Mekong, being still alive in Laos when the time runs out, being taken prisoner, and the six ways the trail can kill. Each villager has 10 endings, 160 in all, and no two are alike. They are the same whichever side of the card the villager was played on. The villagers are invented, but every ending is drawn from the real-life stories of Hmong families who lived through these years.

Finding an ending

An ending is named by the villager and a number, for example **Mai 7**. The numbers mean the same thing for every villager, so the number alone tells the fate. Turn to the villager's pages (the table below) and read the ending with that number.

1. **What became of them?** Find the row in the table and read off the number. A death on the trail is read by its cause, the way the game told it: killed in a fight, starved, taken by sickness or the cold, or an old bomb or a mine. The river has its own rows for drowning and for being shot.
2. **If the villager crossed** there are two endings: **draw a Fortune card**, 1 to 10 reads ending 1, 11 to 20 reads ending 2. The app draws it for you and shows the same code.
3. **Read it aloud**, then the next villager. The family record below keeps track during the game.

ENDING	WHAT BECAME OF THE VILLAGER
1	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 1–10
2	Crossed the Mekong · Fortune 11–20
3	Still in Laos when the game ends · also for going down to surrender
4	Taken prisoner
5	Killed by soldiers · wounds in a fight
6	Starved
7	Died of sickness · fever, the Winter Toll, the yellow rain
8	Killed by a bomb or a mine · an old bomb, a mine
9	Drowned in the Mekong · swept away, a raft or boat lost, the current
10	Shot trying to cross · at the bank or in the water

The villagers

VILLAGER	ENDINGS	PAGE
Chai · Senglao (Mayor) · Side B, Senglao in exile	1–10	6
Tou · Teacher · Side B, Teacher who reads Thai and Lao	1–10	8
Mai · Farmer · Side B, Rice farmer, mother of two	1–10	10
Chao · Kid · Side B, Kid, message runner	1–10	12
Gao · Kid · Side B, Kid, little mother	1–10	14
Sheng · Hunter · Side B, Crossbow hunter	1–10	16
Chong · Blacksmith · Side B, Raft builder	1–10	18
Meng · Shaman · Side B, Shaman who reads the bones	1–10	20
Pao · Farmer · Side B, Fisherman-farmer, strong swimmer	1–10	22
Blong · Elder · Side B, Elder who knows the old roads	1–10	24

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Cheng · Soldier · Side B, SGU radio operator	1–10	**26**
Kong · Doctor · Side B, Medic trained at Sam Thong	1–10	**28**
Lee · Medicine Woman · Side B, Herbalist	1–10	**30**
Bao · Tailor · Side B, Tailor of warm clothes	1–10	**32**
Ka · Singer · Side B, Kwv txhiaj singer	1–10	**34**
Pa · Shaman · Side B, Shaman, soul caller	1–10	**36**

Family record

Fill this in as you play, so you know which ending to read for each villager. When a villager dies on the way, write when and how, for example: "Mai, Fall of 1977, starved in the bamboo forest: Mai 6."

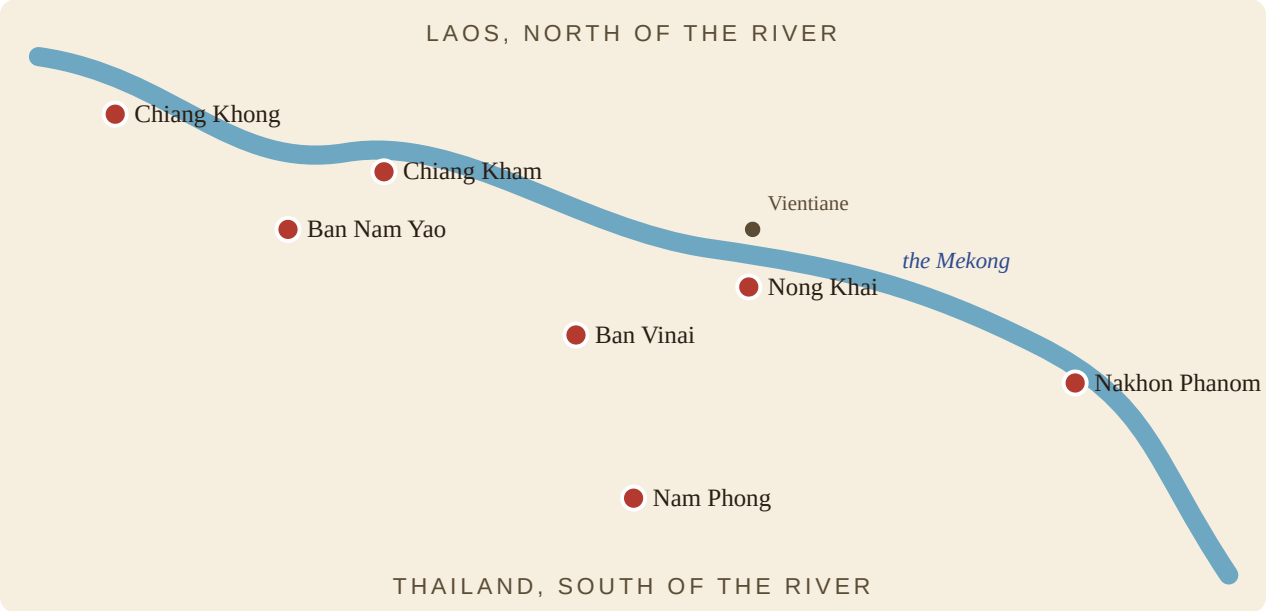
VILLAGER	WHAT BECAME OF THEM	SEASON AND YEAR	WHERE	ENDING

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THE FAR BANK

The camps, and where they went

Every crossed ending (1 and 2) ends on this bank. The camps are where the villagers' stories went on: a family that reached the water near Vientiane was taken to Nong Khai, one that crossed in Loei went to Ban Vinai, one that came down from Sayaboury to Nan.



Chiang Khong: the crossing from the north.

Ban Nam Yao: the camp in Nan, for families from Sayaboury.

Chiang Kham: the camp for the northern crossings.

Ban Vinai: the big Hmong camp, in Loei, where most families waited.

Nong Khai: the first camp, across from Vientiane.

Nam Phong: the earliest camp, inland, soon closed.

Nakhon Phanom: the camp downriver.

Where they went

The camps were a wait, for most families a long one: years of registration lines, of letters to relatives already abroad, of interviews with the officers of the countries that would take them, of being told no and trying again. From the camps the Hmong went to the United States, to France and French Guiana, to Australia, to Canada and to Argentina, in that order of numbers; many were resettled in cities that had never heard of Laos. Some stayed in the camps until they closed, and some were sent back across the river. A few of the endings in this book say which country a villager reached; most stop at the bank, because that is where the game stops, and the rest of the story belongs to the families who lived it.

The map is a sketch, not a survey: the river runs from the north-west to the south-east, and the camps lie along the Thai bank roughly where the families who crossed nearest to them were taken.

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Chai



Senglao (Mayor); on Side B, Senglao in exile. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chai 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Last Wave to St. Paul. Chai reached Ban Vinai in 1976 and was chosen to speak for his section, counting rations and settling disputes. He refused resettlement for years, saying a headman should not leave while his people waited. When Ban Vinai closed in the early 1990s he moved to Wat Tham Krabok, and in 2005 he flew to St. Paul with the last wave, past seventy. His son and his nephews, grown men raised in camps, took warehouse jobs and learned English late. One grandson dropped out of high school and drifted for years; a granddaughter became a nurse and translated at Chai's own appointments. Chai sat with the clan elders at New Year and funerals, and his grandchildren took him to the Capitol memorial, where he stood a long time. He died in St. Paul in 2019.

Chai 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Bringing the Families to Fresno. Chai crossed in 1975 and spent about a year in Nong Khai before his families were resettled, scattered across three states. He went to a small Midwestern town and cleaned a school at night for less than three dollars an hour. The winters and the scattering wore on everyone. In the early 1980s he called the families together by letter and proposed Fresno, where relatives lived. Over two years they moved and worked the fields. His daughter finished college and became a county social worker; his son left high school to farm and never went back. Chai sat as an elder at weddings and funerals across the valley, visited Laos in the late 1990s, and lived to bring great-grandchildren to the Lao Hmong American War Memorial in Courthouse Park.

Chai 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seminar Without an End. When the escape failed, the new authorities came for village leaders first. Chai was taken to a re-education camp, told it would be a short seminar. He spent nearly seven years clearing fields and building roads. Released in the early 1980s, thin and quiet, he was settled in a lowland village and forbidden to travel. Relatives in Fresno sent letters and, later, money. He never crossed. He died in Laos in the late 1990s, and a grandson flew from California for the funeral.

Chai 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Letters from the Roads. Soldiers stopped the group at a stream crossing, and Chai stepped forward and said he was the village leader. They took him and let the families go on. He was held in Camp 06 near Muang Et, repairing roads and digging irrigation ditches. Family visits were refused, but a cousin bribed a guard to pass him dried meat and a little medicine. He kept the wrapping cloth folded in his shirt. He was released in the 1980s, very thin, and settled in a lowland village under watch. Even there, neighbours came to him to settle disputes, and he did it quietly in the evenings. Later his son found a way across the Mekong for the family. They passed through Ban Vinai and were resettled in the United States. Chai kept that wrapping cloth until he died.

Chai 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Cave Above the Stream. In April 1977, the families Chai kept together were hiding in limestone caves between Luang Prabang and Vientiane, the entrances hung with branches. Soldiers found them at night. Gunfire and grenades echoed off the rock, and people fled down the stream in the dark. Chai held the cave mouth long enough for the women and children to get out. In the morning they came back for him. No qeej could be played so near the soldiers; an old man chanted the showing-the-way under his breath. Chai's daughter Gao, who escaped that night, later named the council her family still holds in Merced after the cave.

Chai 6 — STARVED

The Headman Ate Last. By January 1979 Chai's people had spent three months in a limestone cave in the Vang Vieng hills, too watched to plant. Each evening he measured the rice himself, one cup at a time, and took his own share last. Often there was nothing left for him, and when there was, he slipped it to the children. His wife scolded him; he said a headman eats last or he is no headman. He grew thin, then quiet, and died one cold night in his blanket. They buried him at the cave's mouth. His grandson, who crossed the next year, still tells the story in St. Paul each New Year.

Chai 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever by the Nam Ngum. The rains of 1976 found Chai's people camped in the Nam Ngum valley, under plastic sheets that never dried. Dysentery came through the camp. Chai kept walking from shelter to shelter with his notebook, counting who was sick and who had rice, until one morning he could not stand. He lay four days in a lean-to while his wife boiled bark tea and the rain drummed overhead. He died before dawn. A nephew who knew the funeral songs sang the showing-the-way chant in a low voice. The families chose Chai's eldest son to lead them. He kept the notebook and wrote his father's name at the top of a fresh page.

Chai 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Gap in the Dike. In the cold season of 1979 Chai brought his families down onto the Vientiane plain, where the paddies were dry and the dikes made paths a family could walk in the dark. The soldiers had learned that too. At a gap where the path crossed a ditch, Chai went through first, as he always did, to see that it was safe for the children. The mine was in the gap. The families could not stay; his eldest son covered him with his own jacket and led them on, and they crossed the river four nights later. In camp the council met without him for the first time. They left his seat empty, and his son spoke only after the elders had spoken.

Chai 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Bags of Air. Near Paksane, Chai's people went into the Mekong at night holding plastic bags tied full of air. Chai swam last, behind the slowest family, counting heads under his breath. Halfway across, one of the bags burst and a boy went under. Chai caught him and pushed him onto his own float. Then the current took him. On the Thai bank at first light his sons searched the shallows until the police came. In Ban Vinai his wife dried the household notebook page by page in the sun.

Chai 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Senglao Stood Up. Near Thadeua, Chai stood at the water's edge sending his households in one at a time, counting each off as it went. A flare went up while the last family was still on the bank. Chai pushed them down into the reeds and stood, so the soldiers would look at him. He fell where the mud met the water. In the dark that followed, the last family crossed. In Ban Vinai, his eldest son found his own name written at the top of the notebook's last page: the next senglao.

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Tou



Teacher; on Side B, Teacher who reads Thai and Lao. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Tou 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Teacher Teaches Again. Tou reached Ban Vinai in 1977 and was teaching within a month, under a tin roof with no walls, the Hmong alphabet in the morning and arithmetic in the afternoon. In 1980 the family was resettled to St. Paul. He worked nights on a factory line and studied English by day through his first winter. By the end of the decade he was a bilingual aide in St. Paul schools, and later earned his teaching license. His son became a teacher too. His daughter left college after one year and works at a bank; she understands Hmong but answers in English, which hurt him more than he said. Tou taught Saturday Hmong classes for twenty years, visited Laos in 2005 to find his old school, and now reads to his grandchildren in both languages.

Tou 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Court Interpreter in St. Paul. Tou crossed in 1975 and spent a year in Nong Khai translating between Thai guards and Hmong families. He reached St. Paul in 1976, among the first Hmong there, and cleaned offices at night while a church sponsor drove him to English class. His English came quickly. By the late 1980s he interpreted in St. Paul courts and hospitals, careful with every word because he had seen what a wrong one could cost. His daughter became a lawyer. His son enlisted in the Army, served overseas and came home quieter, and the two found it hard to talk. Tou trained younger interpreters, kept a worn Thai-Lao dictionary on his desk until he retired, and went back to Vientiane in 2010 to read the street signs again.

Tou 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Clerk of the Chao Fa. After the failed crossing, Tou hid in the forest with relatives and joined the Chao Fa around Phou Bia. Because he could write, he kept their records and taught children between moves. When the Phou Bia strongholds came under attack in 1977-78, the camps scattered. Tou reached Thailand in 1980 and lived in Ban Vinai for over ten years before resettling in the United States in 1991. He rarely spoke of the forest years, but kept the records.

Tou 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Charcoal on a Board. Tou was captured on the trail with a notebook in his pocket, and that was enough. The soldiers said a man who could write had worked for the Americans. He was sent to Camp 04 near Muang Et. By day he cut logs and cleared brush. At night, by the fire, he taught younger prisoners to read, writing letters in charcoal on a flat board and wiping it with his sleeve when a guard came near. Food was short, and the men shared salt and wild greens. The government said in 1984 that the centres were closed, but Tou was still there. He was released in 1989 and settled near the Plain of Jars. He taught his grandchildren the same letters on the same kind of board, and they never knew why he laughed when they wiped it with their sleeves.

Tou 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Gathering Ferns at Dusk. In the wet season of 1976, Tou's group hid in the forest above the Vang Vieng road. Food ran short, and every afternoon the adults went out to gather fiddlehead ferns and dig for roots. Tou took the older pupils with him and named each plant as they picked it, as if it were a lesson. One evening soldiers waiting by a stream opened fire. Tou shouted for the children to scatter. They did, and all of them came back. He did not. His wife wrapped him in a blanket, and the group moved before dawn. In Ban Vinai, one of those pupils taught the same plant names to her own class.

Tou 6 STARVED

A Handful for Each Child. In the winter of 1978, Tou held school in a clearing in the Vang Vieng hills, scratching letters in the dirt. By then the families had almost no rice. Tou gave his share to the pupils who came with nothing, a handful each, saying children could not learn on empty stomachs. His wife begged him to eat. He grew so thin his shirt hung like a sack, and in February he died in his sleep. The families buried him at the clearing's edge. A boy he had taught crossed to Thailand and became a teacher in Ban Vinai. He opened his first class with Tou's name.

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Tou 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Malaria in the Rains. In August 1976, Tou's group camped in the forest near Muang Fuang, waiting for the rains to ease. Mosquitoes came at dusk in clouds. Tou caught a fever that came and went, chills and then burning, for two weeks. Between fevers he translated a Lao radio broadcast for the others and drew a map of the river towns he knew. Then the fever came and did not leave. He died with his wife beside him. They had no qeej, so the group's elder sang the showing-the-way. His map survived in his wife's bundle, and the family used it to find the river two years later.

Tou 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Iron in the Rice Field. In 1977 Tou's family came down from the hills to a hidden valley near the Plain of Jars, where an old field could be planted again. The ground was full of rusted war scrap. Tou had read the warning leaflets in Lao and knew what to fear, and he went first, probing the soil with a stick. His hoe struck a small round bomb half buried in the earth. The family did not plant that field. Instead they moved on, carrying him. In Ban Vinai, his daughter learned to read Thai from the camp schoolbooks so she could do what her father had done, reading for others.

Tou 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Three Pupils Reached the Bank. Tou had taught three of his oldest pupils to swim in a forest stream, practising each evening for a month. On a dark night they went into the Mekong below Sanakham, holding plastic bags tied full of air. The cold water took his strength halfway. He kept calling to the children to kick, until they could no longer hear him. All three reached the Thai bank. In Ban Vinai his wife held a funeral without a body, and the three pupils burned joss paper beside his empty sleeping mat.

Tou 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Long Enough. Near Paksane, Tou went down to the water first, as he always did, to speak to anyone waiting there. A patrol was waiting. He called out to them in Lao, calmly, the way he had at every checkpoint, and for a moment no one moved. Then a soldier fired. Behind him, while every eye was on him, his family slipped from the reeds into the river and reached Thailand. In Ban Vinai his son said his father had talked one last time, long enough.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Mai



Farmer; on Side B, Rice farmer, mother of two. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Mai 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Rented Acres Near Fresno. Mai spent four years in Ban Vinai, growing greens beside the longhouse and sewing story cloths that traders bought for sale abroad. In 1981 the family was resettled to Fresno. She and her husband picked fruit by the bin and took English classes neither could keep up with. Within a few years they rented a few acres and grew long beans, bitter melon and lemongrass, selling first from a folding table, then at farmers' markets. Their eldest son left high school to work the farm and later ran it. Their daughter studied pharmacy and works in a hospital, the first in the family with a degree. Mai cooked for New Year every year, went back to Laos in 2003 to see her sister, and still plants mustard greens along the fence from seed she carried in a cloth pouch.

Mai 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Strawberries in Merced. Mai crossed in 1979 and spent seven years in Thai camps, the last of them in Chiang Kham, growing vegetables in a strip along the fence. In 1986 the family was resettled to Merced, California. She and her husband picked tomatoes, then rented two acres and grew strawberries, working before dawn under plastic tunnels. Mai never learned to drive, so her eldest daughter drove her to the market at sixteen. One son struggled in school and joined a gang for a time, then came back to work the farm. A daughter became a pharmacist. Mai's mother stayed in Laos, and they spoke only twice more, by phone. Mai still keeps a garden behind the house.

Mai 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still in Xieng Khouang. After the escape failed, Mai and her husband lived two years in the forest, moving with the seasons. In 1978 they came down and were settled in a government village, where they were made to farm a second plot for the cooperative. They stayed. Mai raised five children in Laos and lived to be an old woman. In the 2000s a nephew from St. Paul came to visit, bringing photographs of cousins she had never met, and she cooked for him until he could eat no more.

Mai 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

A Plot for the State. Mai was caught with her basket of food when soldiers stopped her group on the trail. She was a farmer with no papers, so she and her children were sent to the Plain of Jars with other captured families. There they joined an agricultural cooperative under government control. Mai was given a plot for the cooperative and a small one for her own family. She worked both, and she knew which roots and greens grew wild along the paddy edges, so her children rarely went to bed hungry. She saved seed from every harvest in gourds hung from the roof. Officials came often to count and record. Mai stayed all her life, raised her children there, and at New Year she cooked enough for the neighbours whose gardens had failed.

Mai 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Gathering for Two Children. Mai fed her two small children by foraging. In the cold season of 1977, near the Vang Vieng hills, she spent long days digging wild yams and gathering greens while her husband watched the children. Soldiers found the women gathering by a stream. Mai ran the wrong way and was shot. The other women brought back her basket. Her husband raised the children alone, and the family held a funeral for her when they reached the camp, calling her soul home. Her son, grown, says his mother's basket was the last thing she carried for them.

Mai 6 — STARVED

Rice Water for the Children. By the cold season of 1977, Mai's family had been in the forest near the Nam Ngum for a year. She cooked thin rice water for the children and drank only what was left in the pot. When there was no rice, she boiled leaves and gave the children the broth. Her husband found her once eating bark. She grew weak and slow, then caught a cough she could not throw off. She died in January. Her husband led the children across the river that spring. In Merced, her youngest son keeps a sack of rice in the pantry at all times and says he cannot sleep if it runs low.

Mai 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Sickness at the Stream. Late in the rains of 1976, Mai's family camped beside a stream in the Vang Vieng hills, where they could hide but could not plant. The water was the only water. First the baby fell sick with dysentery, then Mai, who had nursed him day and night. The baby recovered. Mai did not. She died in a shelter of banana leaves while her husband held her hand. No qeej player was with them; her husband's uncle sang the showing-the-way chant, telling her to follow the road back to the place where her birth shirt was buried. Her husband raised the children alone and never remarried.

Mai 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Field Her Husband Cleared. In 1976 Mai went back to the field her husband had cleared on a slope near Muang Cha, because her children had to eat. The slope had been bombed during the war, and rusted metal lay among the stumps. Mai burned the brush and began hoeing the ground for rice. Her hoe struck something buried. Her neighbors heard the blast from the valley. Her children were in the village with their grandmother. The family held the funeral in the village, with qeej and drums. Her son later worked with a group clearing old bombs in Laos, to make the ground safe for others.

Mai 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Seed Gourds, Dry. The family crossed below Pak Lay on a raft of banana stems lashed with vine, too small for five. Mai slipped into the water to lighten it and swam beside, one hand on the stems, pushing. Halfway over, the raft turned in an eddy and her hand came away. Her husband saw her once against the Thai lights. She was never found. On the Thai bank the children opened her basket: rice, salt and her seed gourds, still dry. Her daughter in Fresno still plants from that line of seed.

Mai 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Her Back to the Shore. The family reached the reeds at night with a hired guide. Mai went first with the youngest on her back, feeling for the mud with her feet. A flare went up on the Lao bank and soldiers fired at the water's edge. Mai turned her back to the shore to cover the boy and was hit. Her husband carried the child the rest of the way. The boy was unhurt. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called his frightened soul back, and the family held Mai's funeral.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Chao



Kid; on Side B, Kid, message runner. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Nurse on the East Side. Chao was ten when his family reached Ban Vinai in 1978, and he spent a year there learning letters in the camp school. In 1979 they were resettled to St. Paul. He was placed in third grade with children half his size and learned English from cartoons and a patient teacher. His father cleaned floors at a downtown bank. In high school Chao translated for his parents at clinics, which is why he became a nurse; he worked twenty-five years at a St. Paul hospital, often called when an elderly Hmong patient would not speak. His son became an engineer; his daughter struggled with depression in college and took years to finish. Chao took his mother to New Year every year, visited Laos with her in 2010, and now babysits his grandchildren.

Chao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Snowfall in Wausau. Chao was eleven when his family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Nong Khai camp, in tarp tents that flooded every time it rained. In 1980 they were resettled to Wausau, Wisconsin. Snow fell the first week. Chao learned English fast and translated for his parents everywhere. Some classmates were friendly; others threw stones and shouted that the Hmong should go home. He fought back, then learned not to. He became a social worker for the county, the job he had done unpaid since age eleven. His sister Gao never liked the cold and moved to Fresno. In 2016 Chao brought his father to the unveiling of the Hmong-Lao veterans memorial in Wausau.

Chao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Grown in the Forest. Chao's family was turned back and fled into the forest near Phou Bia. He grew up there, moving camp every few weeks, without school or a clinic. As a young man he joined the remaining Chao Fa groups and stayed after most others had surrendered or crossed. He married in the forest. People of his generation are still hiding there, now with grandchildren.

Chao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Raised in the Cooperative. Chao was a small boy when soldiers caught him on the trail, separated from his parents in the noise of the fight. He was sent with other captured children and women to a resettlement village on the Plain of Jars. An older couple in the cooperative took him in and raised him with their own grandchildren. He herded buffalo, went to the village school and learned to read Lao. He never stopped asking about his parents. When he was grown, a trader brought a letter from Ban Vinai: his mother and father were alive and had crossed the river. They were later resettled in the United States. In the 1990s his mother flew back to Laos to see him. She brought him an embroidered collar she had sewn the year he was lost.

Chao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Night in the Cave. In April 1977, Chao's family was sleeping in a limestone cave between Luang Prabang and Vientiane, with several other families. The entrance was hung with branches, and the cooking fire was kept small. Soldiers came in the night. In the noise and dark, Chao's father got the little ones out, but Chao, who was ten, had run back for his younger cousin. Both were lost. The families buried the children together the next evening, in a clearing below the cave. His father sang the showing-the-way chant for both. His mother kept his slingshot. In St. Paul, decades later, she gave it to her first grandson and told him whose it had been.

Chao 6 STARVED

Waiting for Grandfather. Chao's family would not leave the forest near Phou Bia without his grandfather, who was too sick to walk. So they stayed, through the dry season of 1978 and into the rains. The rice ran out, then the corn. They ate leaves and banana stems and whatever small fish Chao could catch in the stream. His grandfather died in May. By then Chao, ten, was thin as a stick, and a cough settled in his chest. He died a month later. The family crossed the river in October. In Ban Vinai, his father held one funeral for both, with qeej, though he could not afford a cow.

Chao 7 — DIED OF SICKNESS

The Fever in the Rains. Chao was eight in the wet season of 1976, when his family hid in the forest near the Nam Ngum. Everything was damp: blankets, rice, the ground they slept on. A fever went through the children. Chao had it for a week, burning and then shivering, while his mother kept a wet cloth on his forehead and sang to him. He seemed to get better, and then one night he did not wake. His father carved a small wooden top for him to take along. The elder sang the showing-the-way chant. His mother crossed with his embroidered collar sewn inside her own jacket, and wore that jacket at every New Year for the rest of her life.

Chao 8 — KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Bright Thing in the Grass. In the dry season of 1977 Chao's family crossed the bombed hills of Xieng Khouang, where the old fields were pocked with craters and every child had been told never to touch the small round bombs. Chao, nine, ran ahead as he always did. At a crater's edge he saw one half out of the earth, grey and round as a fruit, and he reached for it to show his father. His father heard the sound from the path. They wrapped him in his mother's skirt and buried him beside the crater, and his father spoke the words that show a soul the way home. His mother kept his slingshot. In St. Paul, years later, she would not let her grandchildren pick up anything from the ground in a park.

Chao 9 — DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Two Plastic Bags. The family swam the Mekong below Vientiane at night. Chao, nine, floated between two plastic bags full of air that his father had tied under his arms. Halfway across, one bag tore on a snag, and the current carried him off into the dark. He called his father once. His father dove again and again until his mother pulled him back. Chao was not found. In Nong Khai camp the elders sang the showing-the-way for him, and his mother kept his embroidered hat for the rest of her life.

Chao 10 — SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Path He Scouted. The family reached the water's edge near Sanakham before moonrise. Chao, ten, had scouted the path down through the reeds himself. As they stepped into the river, soldiers on the bank fired toward the sound, and Chao fell in the shallows. His father carried him across in his arms, but the boy was gone before they reached Thailand. Two Thai farmers helped dig a grave above the bank. In Minneapolis his mother sewed his hat's pattern into every grandchild's New Year collar.

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Gao



Kid; on Side B, Kid, little mother. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Gao 1 · CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Snow in Sheboygan. Gao crossed in 1976 and spent a year in the Nong Khai camp, on the Hmong side where there was no electricity, carrying water and learning Thai letters from a volunteer. Late in 1977 a Lutheran congregation sponsored the family to Sheboygan, Wisconsin. Her mother cleaned motel rooms on the lake road, and Gao started second grade at eight with no English, in snow up to her knees. She worked twenty years on the line at the Kohler plant, then ran the garden plots the city set aside for Hmong families by the river. Her son joined the Army and served two tours overseas; he came home quieter, and she learned to sit with him the way she sat with old soldiers. Her daughter left college, then went back at thirty and became a social worker. In 2006 Gao walked her mother to the Deland Park memorial. She now has six grandchildren.

Gao 2 · CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Merced Classroom. Gao's family spent two years in Ban Vinai, where she went to the camp school and her mother sewed story cloths to sell to aid workers. A cousin sponsored them to Merced, California, in 1980. Her father picked crops and studied English at night until his eyes gave out. At eleven Gao read the welfare letters aloud at the kitchen table. She finished college and taught English to newcomers' children for twenty-five years; in 2005 the last families from Wat Tham Krabok arrived and their children sat in her room. Her elder son became a pharmacist. Her younger son ran with a gang in the late 1990s, spent a year in juvenile hall, and now counsels teenagers for the county. Gao sits on the New Year committee and took her mother back to Laos in 2012.

Gao 3 · STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

The Cassette Letters. When the group scattered, Gao stayed behind with her grandmother. For years they moved through the forest with other families, planting small hidden fields. In the early 1980s they came down to a lowland village, and Gao grew up there, married and raised five children. She never crossed. In the 1990s a cassette tape arrived from cousins in California, full of greetings and old songs, and she recorded one back. She first saw them again in 2008, when they visited with gifts and photographs. She told them she did not regret staying, only the parting.

Gao 4 · TAKEN PRISONER

Raised by the Cooperative. Gao was eight when the soldiers stopped her group on the trail. Her parents had gone ahead to scout the path, and they never came back for her. She was sent with other captured families to a cooperative on the Plain of Jars, where an older widow took her in. She carried water, weeded the rice and learned Lao at the village school. Each evening she said her parents' names quietly so she would not forget them. She married a quiet man from the cooperative and kept her mother's silver necklace sewn inside a pillow. In 1996 a letter came through a cousin in Vientiane. Her parents had crossed the river and were living in Wisconsin. They came back two years later. Her mother knew her at once, by her calm way of standing still.

Gao 5 · KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Back of the Cave. In the spring of 1977 Gao's group hid in caves in the limestone hills between Luang Prabang and Vientiane. A crying baby could give everyone away, so the mothers gave the smallest a little opium on the tongue, and Gao slept with her baby cousin inside her blouse. Soldiers attacked the caves before dawn. Gao pressed herself over the baby against the back wall. When the shooting stopped, his mother found the boy alive and warm beneath her. The survivors left before light, with no time for a funeral. In Ban Vinai an elder chanted the showing-the-way for her. That cousin, now a grandfather in Saint Paul, tells the story every New Year so his grandchildren know whose life they carry.

Gao 6 · STARVED

A Winter Underground. When the offensive reached Phou Bia late in 1978, Gao's family and four others hid in a limestone cave and lived there through the cold months. The fire was kept to embers so the smoke would not show, and water dripped from the ceiling day and night. They went out only after dark, to dig roots and glean the last corn from abandoned fields. Gao gave her share of corn gruel to her grandmother more than once and said she was not hungry. In January she grew too weak to climb to the cave mouth. She died there, and they buried her under the overhang. Her grandmother lived to reach Ban Vinai and asked for a soul-release rite to be held for Gao, a year late.

Gao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever in the Rains. In the rains of 1977 Gao's family sheltered under banana-leaf roofs on the slopes below Phou Bia, moving camp whenever smoke from soldiers' fires showed in the valley. Gao caught a fever that came back every second afternoon and shook her until her teeth knocked. There was no medicine. Her grandmother boiled bitter bark and called Gao's soul at dawn with the family's last hen, singing her name toward the trees. On the ninth day Gao fell asleep and did not wake. Her father buried her on a ridge, without the qeej, because the sound would carry. Her mother kept the collar Gao had embroidered herself, crooked stitches and all, and forty years later in Minnesota asked to be buried with it.

Gao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

A Round Thing in the Grass. In the dry season of 1976 Gao's family walked south across the hills of Xieng Khouang, where years of bombing had left the old fields full of rusted metal. Every child had been warned never to touch the small round bombs. Gao was gathering firewood at the edge of a burned clearing when her stick turned one over. Her uncle heard the sound from the trail. The family could not stay. They wrapped her in her mother's skirt and buried her under a stand of bamboo, and her father spoke the words that show a soul the way back to the ancestors. In Ban Vinai her mother sewed a story cloth of the walk, with one small girl carrying sticks, a little apart from the rest.

Gao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Raft in the Dark. She was on a raft of banana trunks, holding her grandmother's hand, when the raft struck a sunken tree and broke apart in the dark. Her grandmother came up alone. When a patrol light swept the water, the family stayed silent, as Gao had always helped them do. They searched the Thai sandbars for two days. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with qeej and laid her silver neck ring where she should have been.

Gao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Quiet Child to the Last. Gao was holding her grandmother's hand in the shallows when soldiers on the bank saw the raft being pushed out and fired into the dark. She fell into the water without a sound. Her father lifted her onto the raft and would not leave her, and the family brought her across. They buried her near the Nong Khai camp, with the qeej for one night. Her grandmother kept the little pouch Gao had sewn, with three river stones still inside.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Sheng



Hunter; on Side B, Crossbow hunter. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Sheng 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Deer Season in Wausau. Sheng reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and spent a year there making paj ntaub with other women while her husband, a former soldier, recovered from fever. A Catholic parish sponsored them to Wausau, Wisconsin, in 1980. She worked nights at a cheese plant and went to English class in the mornings, half asleep. The first winter frightened her more than the war had. Each November she bought a deer licence and walked the county forest with her sons, and the venison went to New Year feasts and widows with no hunter. Her eldest son dropped out of high school and worked forty years in a paper mill; her daughter became a teacher. Her husband died in 2014. In 2016 she stood at the new veterans memorial at the courthouse for him. Her grandsons still hunt with her rifle.

Sheng 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Grouse in Ontario. Sheng's family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Ban Vinai, where she wove baskets for trade and waited for a sponsor. Canada accepted them in 1980, one of a small number of Hmong families sent there, and placed them in a city in Ontario where the nearest Hmong household was an hour's drive away. Her husband worked in a plastics factory; Sheng sewed at a coat factory and learned English from a church volunteer. In the autumns she hunted grouse and deer with a licensed rifle, and the meat went to the few Hmong families nearby. Her daughter became a high school teacher. Her son moved to Minnesota to live among other Hmong and married there. Sheng stayed, saying the forest was big enough.

Sheng 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Hunter for the Hidden. Sheng stayed in the mountains when the escape failed and hunted for families hiding near Phou Bia. When the army pushed into the massif in 1977 and 1978, her group kept moving, eating roots in the dry months. She crossed the Mekong at last in 1983 with a small group of women and children and spent years in Thai camps. In 1992 she reached the United States. She never hunted again, saying she had done enough of it to stay alive. Her granddaughter recorded her story for a school project.

Sheng 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Rifle on the Trail. Sheng was caught with a rifle in her hands, and that changed everything. The soldiers did not believe a woman carried it only for hunting. She was sent to a seminar camp in Houaphan, known only by its number, near Muang Xamteu. The officers called it a school. She cut logs, dug irrigation ditches and repaired roads in the rain. When the rice was cut, she set snares at the edge of the work site and shared the birds with the women in her hut. Family visits were refused. She was released in 1984 and walked home to find her husband had remarried, believing her dead. She settled near her sister instead, raised pigs and never touched a gun again.

Sheng 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Her Snares at Dawn. In the rainy season of 1978 Sheng's family hid in the forest on the flanks of Phou Bia, moving camp every few weeks. She went out at first light to check her snares and dig wild yams, because she knew the ground better than any of the men. One morning, crossing a stream, she walked into a patrol. The camp heard two shots. Her husband found her that evening and carried her back. They buried her the same night with her knife and her bag of snares beside her, and he spoke the words that show the way back to the ancestors. He raised their sons alone, in Ban Vinai and later in Wisconsin. When the eldest bought his first hunting licence, his father gave him her knife.

Sheng 6 — STARVED

Too Close to Light a Fire. In the dry season of 1978 Sheng's group was hiding in the Vang Vieng hills, too close to patrols to hunt with a gun or light a fire by day. The game had moved off, and they lived on wild yams. Sheng knew the bitter kind had to be sliced and soaked in running water for days, but the group kept moving and the soaking was cut short. She always tasted each batch first, to judge it for the children. One night she fell ill with cramps and dizziness and died before morning. The children who had eaten after her were only sick. Her brother made sure every batch after that soaked the full time, and later taught her daughter which roots to dig and which to leave.

Sheng 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Fever Took the Hunter. In the rains of 1977 Sheng's family hid on the slopes below Phou Bia, and she went out each dawn to her snares. The fever came with the mosquitoes, shaking her every second day. On the good days she still walked her lines and brought back squirrels and once a barking deer; on the bad days her husband walked them for her and came back with nothing. By the fifth week she could not stand. She told her nephew where every snare was set before she slept. She died before dawn. There was no qeej, so her brother chanted the showing-the-way under his breath. The nephew ran her snares until the family left for the river, and in Ban Vinai he fed them the same way.

Sheng 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Off the Guide's Line. Late in 1979 Sheng's family took the long western route through the hills of Xayaboury, and she hunted as they walked and kept the family fed. On the fifth day, crossing a dry streambed, a small child wandered off the trodden path toward a bird in the stones, and Sheng stepped out to lift her back. The mine took Sheng, and the child was thrown clear, frightened but whole. The group buried her quickly in a clearing, and her brother tied a strip of red cloth to a tree so the place could be found again. It never was. The family reached Sob Tuang camp in January. Each New Year her husband still burns spirit money for her.

Sheng 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Pushing from Behind. She swam behind the bamboo raft her husband had lashed together in the reeds, pushing it toward Thailand while her sons clung to the poles. In the middle the current swung the raft into a sunken tree, and she was pulled under its branches. Her husband felt her hands leave the raft. The boys reached the Thai bank at dawn. In Nong Khai camp the family held her funeral with qeej and laid her knife where she should have been.

Sheng 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

A Hunter's Ears. Sheng heard the patrol before anyone else, as she always did, and stood up in the shallows to wave the others on. The soldiers on the bank fired at the movement. She went down in the shallows while her husband and sons were already pushing off on the raft, and he could not go back. On the Thai bank they listened all night. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with her hunting bag laid out, and her husband told everyone she had bought them the minutes they needed.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Chong



Blacksmith; on Side B, Raft builder. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Chong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Knives from Leaf Springs. In Ban Vinai, Chong built a forge from scrap and spent two years mending pots and making knives for the camp. A church sponsored his family to Sheboygan, Wisconsin, in 1978. He worked in a metal shop grinding castings for $2.90 an hour and went to English class at night, though he spoke little. In his garage he built a forge from a brake drum and turned old truck leaf springs into Hmong knives, sickles and hoes; neighbours with gardens bought them, then Hmong families from Wausau and Milwaukee. His eldest son became an engineer at a manufacturer. His daughter left school at seventeen to marry, then went back years later to become a nurse. At New Year Chong gave a knife to every boy who had turned twelve. When he died, his grandson kept the anvil and still makes two knives each winter.

Chong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Abuelo at the New Year. Chong's family crossed in 1978 and lived two years in Ban Vinai, where he mended pots at a scrap forge. When Argentina offered places to a small group of Hmong families, Chong, tired of waiting for an American sponsor, said yes. They were placed in a farming town in the north, where the soil was red and the summers hot and wet. Some families soon left for France or the United States. Chong stayed, mending ploughs and gates for neighbours and learning Spanish slowly. His wife grew vegetables and sold them in the town market. His daughter became a schoolteacher; his son moved to French Guiana and farmed there. Chong's grandchildren speak Spanish first and Hmong second, and call him Abuelo at the New Year.

Chong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seminar Years. Chong stayed. Because he had repaired rifles for soldiers during the war, he was sent to a re-education camp, where he did hard labour clearing land and breaking rock. He was released in the mid-1980s and returned to a lowland village, where he forged tools for the cooperative. He never tried to leave. Two of his sons crossed into Thailand and later reached the United States, and in the 1990s they began sending money and photographs. He died in Laos in 2007. His sons flew back for the funeral and heard the qeej played for him.

Chong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Tools for the Guards. Soldiers caught Chong on the trail with his hammer and tongs in his pack. Someone told them he had fixed rifles for the army, and he was sent north to a seminar camp near Muang Et. He was told a seminar could last thirty days or thirty years. The guards soon learned his skill and made him mend axes, hoes and road tools. It kept his hands busy, but the rice was thin. He wrote short letters that were never answered, since visits were refused. In the third winter the rice ran shorter still, and Chong fell ill with fever. He died in the spring. A fellow prisoner later reached Thailand and told his sons where he lay.

Chong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Ladder He Built. When the offensive reached Phou Bia late in 1978, Chong's family and five others took shelter in a limestone cave above a stream. He had made a ladder of bamboo and rattan to reach it and pulled it up every night. One night soldiers found the path anyway and fired into the cave mouth. Chong held the entrance while the others climbed down a narrow chimney at the back that he had found weeks before. He was killed at the mouth. His wife and children escaped through the back. They reached the river a month later and crossed on a raft his nephew lashed the way Chong had taught him. In the Nong Khai camp his widow held the funeral with qeej.

Chong 6 STARVED

Hoes from a Truck Spring. Chong's family stayed in the hills west of Phou Bia through 1976 and planted corn and hill rice in a clearing under tall trees. Chong forged the hoes himself from an old truck spring. In the harvest month soldiers found the field and burned it, with the granary beside it. That winter the family lived on cassava from an abandoned garden, bamboo shoots, and whatever Chong could get by trading his knives. He ate least, saying a smith needed less than a growing child. By spring his legs and face were swollen. He died in April and was buried with his hammer. His wife and children reached Ban Vinai in 1978, and his son still has the hammer in Milwaukee.

Chong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Bad Water. In the wet season of 1977 Chong's family was hiding with forty others in the forest above the Nam Ngum, drinking from a stream that ran past too many camps. Dysentery went through the group. Chong nursed his wife and daughter through it, boiling water whenever smoke was safe, and then he fell ill himself. He kept mending digging tools by hand until the day he could not sit up. He died within a week. There was no qeej player in the group, so an old man chanted the showing-the-way over him through the night, and they buried him with his tongs. His wife carried the tongs to Thailand. His daughter, a public health nurse in Minnesota, teaches safe water to newly arrived families.

Chong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

Steel from the Old Field. Chong had always made his blades from scrap, and the hills of Xieng Khouang were full of it. On the walk south in the cool season of 1976 the family's tools were wearing out, so he stopped at an old bombed field to take steel from a broken casing. Something small and round lay underneath it, and it went off when he moved the casing. His eldest son, twenty steps away, was not hurt. The family wrapped Chong in a blanket and buried him on the hillside at dusk; a cousin chanted the way back to the ancestors, and his son laid the hammer beside him. The son learned the trade again in Ban Vinai, and in Wisconsin he became a welder who never touches metal he cannot name.

Chong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Iron Rings on the Rope. Chong's family crossed below Paksane holding bundles of bamboo, tied together by a rope. Chong had forged an iron ring for each child's float so the rope could not slip. Midstream a snag dragged at the line, and he cut himself free so it would not pull the children under. The current took him. The family reached Thailand at dawn, every ring still holding. His body was never found. In Ban Vinai they held his funeral, and his daughter wears one ring on a chain.

Chong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Armor in the Shallows. Chong's group reached the bank near Pak Lay after midnight. He was wearing the last bamboo armor he had made, and he stood in the shallows holding the floats steady while the others climbed on. A patrol came along the shore with lights. He was shot there, knee-deep in the shallows, and the armor did not stop it. The floats drifted clear, and his wife and children reached the Thai bank. They never learned what was done with his body. In Ban Vinai a cousin led his funeral.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Meng



Shaman; on Side B, Shaman who reads the bones. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Meng 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Gong in the Apartment. Meng spent a year in Ban Vinai, where he held healing rites almost every night. A cousin sponsored his family to Merced, California, in 1980. He went to English class for six months and quit, and the family lived on welfare and his wife's piece-work sewing. He was the only txiv neeb for several apartment blocks, and a landlord complained about the gong more than once. His elder son became a nurse and often stood between doctors and his father, explaining each to the other. His younger son joined a church and stopped coming to the rites, and for years they did not speak of it. Later a Merced hospital began letting shamans perform brief ceremonies at bedsides, and Meng was among those who went. He trained his nephew to keep the altar.

Meng 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Nights of the Qeej. Meng spent five years in Ban Vinai, where he held more funerals than he could count and waited while sponsors fell through. He reached Wausau, Wisconsin, in 1984 and worked as a janitor at a school, a job he kept until he was sixty-five. He led healing rites and New Year soul-calling for dozens of families, and he worked with a funeral home that let the qeej play through the night. He learned to explain the rites to coroners and nurses. His daughter became a social worker; his son left high school, joined the Army, and came home steadier. In 2016 Meng blessed the ground where the veterans memorial was raised at the courthouse. His son now keeps the altar and the shaman's tools, and the grandchildren carry the incense.

Meng 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still on the Mountain. Meng stayed with the families who went up toward Phou Bia, and they relied on him for healing when there was no medicine. He lived through the offensives of 1977 and 1978 and kept moving with a small group in the forest for years. He died there of illness in the 1990s and was buried by people who could not hold a full funeral. Some of the families he served are still in hiding today, without schools or clinics, and reports of attacks on them continued into 2025. They still speak of him.

Meng 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Healing in the Dark. Meng was caught on the trail with his shaman's rattle and finger bells. A village official said he had held ceremonies for soldiers, and he was sent to a seminar camp in Houaphan near Muang Et. The officers called old beliefs superstition, and rituals were forbidden. Meng cut logs by day. At night, when a man lay sick and frightened, Meng whispered the soul calling beside him, using a thread pulled from his own shirt. In 1979 news passed among the prisoners that Touby Lyfoung had died in Camp 01 at Sop Hao. Some said malaria, some a guard. Meng did not say what he thought. He was released in the 1980s and lived quietly with his daughter until he died.

Meng 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Crossing Route 13. In January 1978 Meng's group had to cross Route 13, the main road north of Vientiane, to reach the plain and the river. They waited all day in the elephant grass for their guide and crossed at dusk. A patrol on the road opened fire. Meng was shot as he helped an old woman down the embankment. His elder son dragged him back into the grass, where he died before midnight. They buried him beside a stream, and before they moved on his son tied a white string on each living relative's wrist, as his father had done for them so many times. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb held his funeral with qeej. His sons still argue over whether they should have waited.

Meng 6 STARVED

The Plane Before the Harvest. In 1978 Meng's village, hiding in the forest above the Nam Ngum, risked planting one field of rice in a hollow screened by trees. A week before harvest a plane passed low, and two days later soldiers came and burned the field and the granary. The families scattered. That winter they lived on wild leaves, bamboo shoots and a little corn. Meng held healing rites for the sick on an empty stomach and grew weaker every month. He died in February, wrapped in his shaman's cloth, and his wife sang the old mourning words over him. A year later his elder son held a full funeral in Ban Vinai with a borrowed qeej, and in Saint Paul he still keeps his father's altar.

Meng 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever Among the Sick. In the rains of 1976 Meng was the only txiv neeb among the families hiding in the forest near Phou Bia, and nearly every night someone called him to a sick child. He held healing rites with a cloth over his face and the rattle in his hand, calling lost souls back to bodies burning with fever. In August the fever took him too. His wife and his nephew nursed him in a lean-to for nine days, and he died at dawn. With soldiers close, there was no proper funeral; an elder chanted the showing-the-way in a whisper. In the Nong Khai camp his elder son held the full rites. The son became a nurse in California and keeps his father's rattle on a high shelf.

Meng 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Dry Field. In the hot season of 1979 Meng's family came down from the hills to the plain near Vientiane, where mines had been laid along the escape trails. Meng read the bones the night before and said the path along the paddy dikes was clear. In the morning, cutting across a dry field to avoid a village, his son's wife stumbled, and Meng pulled her back and stepped where she had been. The mine took him. The family buried him quickly at the edge of the field, and his eldest son spoke the words that show the way. In Ban Vinai they held the funeral properly. His sons always defended the old man's bones: he had read the paddy path, not the field.

Meng 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Untied from Her. Meng could not swim. He crossed holding two sealed bamboo tubes, roped to his wife on hers. Midstream his float split and filled. He untied the rope from his own waist so he would not drag her down, and the current took him. She reached the Thai bank at dawn and searched the sandbars for three days. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb of another clan called his soul and held the funeral with qeej and drum. His wife never let anyone tie a rope to her again.

Meng 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Calling the Children Close. Meng's group reached the bank below Paksane after midnight. Before they went in, Meng shook his rattle very softly and called the children's souls to stay close inside their bodies for the crossing. A patrol came up the bank as the first floats went out. Meng was shot in the reeds, the rattle still in his hand. His elder son pulled the floats into the dark. In Nong Khai the family held his funeral with his rattle and horns in his place, and the son tied strings on every child who had crossed.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Pao



Farmer; on Side B, Fisherman-farmer, strong swimmer. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Pao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Cucumbers Under Bedsheets. Pao spent a year in Ban Vinai, growing squash along the camp fence and waiting for a sponsor. In 1977 a Lutheran church brought the family to Denver. He swept a warehouse for $2.50 an hour, studied English two evenings a week, and learned that corn planted in April could freeze. By the third spring he rented a plot outside the city and covered his cucumbers with bedsheets on cold nights. His eldest son left high school at sixteen to work, then earned his diploma at twenty-five and became a diesel mechanic. His daughter became a nurse. Pao stayed in Colorado when cousins moved to Minnesota. In 1995 he stood at the back when Golden declared a Lao-Hmong Recognition Day. He visited his old village once, in 2006, and came home saying the hills had grown smaller.

Pao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Chicken Houses in Arkansas. Pao reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and waited six years. His children went to the camp school, and he planted gourds along the fence and traded them at the gate. In 1985 the family flew to the United States. A cousin found him contract work in Arkansas raising chickens: thousands of birds in long metal houses, fed and watered on a strict schedule. It was farming, and he understood it. His two daughters finished college; one teaches fourth grade, the other is an accountant. His son struggled, fell in with older boys, spent a year in county jail, and came home to work the chicken houses beside him. Pao paid off the land in eleven years. When his knees gave out in 2012 he sold the farm and moved to a Minnesota suburb, where he grows bitter melon and leads his clan's New Year meal.

Pao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Learning the New Ways. After the escape failed, Pao led what was left of the family back down the mountain. In 1976 officials moved them to a lowland village near the road, where they were told to learn the new ways of life and farm a plot for the government. Pao kept quiet and grew rice. In 1979 his two sons slipped away with a large group bound for Thailand. Pao stayed with his wife, whose leg was bad. Letters came from America years apart. He died in the village in 2003, and his neighbours buried him.

Pao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Rice for the Cooperative. The soldiers caught Pao on the trail with a basket of maize seed on his back. They did not shoot him. They walked him and his wife down to a lowland resettlement village, and in 1976 the family was moved again, to a cooperative on the Plain of Jars. Pao was given a plot and a quota. He burned and cleared new fields as he always had, but the rice went to the cooperative store and came back to him by the cup. Officials came to the meetings and watched who was missing. He kept the seed basket on a nail by the door. His sons grew up speaking Lao at school. Pao died in the cooperative, and his sons played the qeej for him on borrowed pipes.

Pao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Shells on the Maize Ridge. In the dry season of 1977, with the offensive closing on Phou Bia, Pao went back up to his abandoned field to cut the last ears of maize. He had planted that slope himself, and he would not let the soldiers have it. The first shells came over the ridge while he was still bent in the rows, and the dry stalks hid nothing. His brother found him at dusk and carried him down to the gully where the family waited. There was no qeej; they could not risk the sound. His brother whispered the showing-the-way chant over him by the light of a resin torch, and the next morning the family walked west carrying a basket of the maize he had cut.

Pao 6 STARVED

The Hunger Sickness. Through the dry season of 1978 Pao's family hid in a ravine in the Vang Vieng hills, too close to a new army post to light a fire by day. The rice had gone in the first month. They lived on cassava dug from an abandoned garden and bamboo shoots, with no salt and no meat, and Pao did the digging. By the hot season his legs had swollen to the knee and then his face, the hunger sickness the old people knew by name. He kept walking to the garden until he could not stand, and died in his sleep before the rains. His wife sang a kwv txhiaj for him at the fire, very low, and the children she brought to Ban Vinai remembered that song all their lives.

Pao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever on the Reservoir. In the rains of 1977 Pao's family hid in the bamboo along the shore of the Nam Ngum reservoir, where he could fish at dawn and feed the others. The mosquitoes came at dusk in clouds. One by one the family took the fever, and Pao went on wading out with his net while it shook him. In August it would not let him go. His wife boiled bark and sat with him for four nights. They buried him in the bamboo, and his son, twelve that year, took over the dawn fishing until the family left for the Mekong. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called the souls of the whole family together so that none would follow Pao away.

Pao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Bomblet in the Furrow. In the Vang Vieng hills in the spring of 1978, Pao cleared a hidden patch under the trees to plant cassava cuttings, far from any path the soldiers used. On the second morning his hoe rang against something round and rusted, a bomblet left from the bombing years. His wife heard the sound from the stream. They buried him beside the patch he had cleared, and his sons covered the grave with leaves so no patrol would find it. The cassava came up anyway. In Minnesota, decades later, his eldest son would not let his grandchildren dig in the garden until he had walked the rows himself, slowly, looking at the ground.

Pao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Back for One More. Pao had already crossed the Mekong four times that night, towing children from three families on a float of banana stems. On the fifth trip he brought over his wife, who could not swim, and left her in the Thai shallows. Then he turned back for his brother's youngest. Halfway out his strength was gone and the current took him. His brother brought the child across at dawn. The family held his funeral in Ban Vinai, and the child he went back for carried the spirit money.

Pao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last Push Off. The family waited in the mud until the moon set. Pao was the last on the bank, pushing the raft with his wife and youngest son into deep water, when a light swung across the reeds and soldiers fired from the shore. He fell face down in the mud of the bank. His wife saw him go down and could only hold the boy and let the current take them. They reached Thailand at first light. In Ban Vinai his brother, who had crossed a week earlier, held his funeral, and the youngest son lit the first spirit money.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Blong



Elder; on Side B, Elder who knows the old roads. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Blong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Elder Everyone Fetched. Blong waited three years in Ban Vinai before his youngest son found a sponsor, and reached Minneapolis in February 1980 in rubber sandals. His son worked nights at a meat plant in South St. Paul. Blong went to English class for one winter and learned 'thank you' and his bus number. What he knew was harder to find: the order of a funeral, the words of a marriage negotiation, which clans could marry. Families drove across the Twin Cities to fetch him. His grandchildren grew up between two languages. One grandson dropped out and was in a gang for a while; Blong sat with him every evening until he went back to school, and he is now a youth counsellor. A granddaughter became a teacher. Blong sat by the drum at three-day funerals in rented halls until he died in 1997, at eighty-six.

Blong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Old Man of Ban Vinai. Blong crossed at sixty-four and reached Ban Vinai in 1976. He never left Thailand. When his sons filled in resettlement forms, he refused to sign: he would not die where no one knew the way back to the ancestors. His youngest son stayed with him while the others went to Minnesota. In the camp's mud lanes Blong settled disputes over bride price and borrowed pigs, and he chanted the song that guides the dead at funerals for younger men. His grandchildren learned Thai and English at the camp school. He died in 1984 and was buried outside the camp. His son left for St. Paul a year later with his father's pipe. Of the grandchildren raised in Ban Vinai, one became a lawyer in St. Paul; another never finished school and drives a truck. Both keep his photograph above their New Year altar.

Blong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Too Old to Hide. When the group turned back, Blong told his sons he was too old to live in the forest. He went home to the village, where officials mostly left an old man alone. His sons went into the forest near Phou Bia. Blong kept a small garden, performed weddings when asked, and waited. One son came out of the forest in 1980 to see him once, then crossed into Thailand. Blong died in 1986. The village buried him with qeej, and his grandson in America heard of it a year later, in a letter.

Blong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

The Old Man's Garden. Blong could not run when the soldiers came up the trail, so he sat down on a rock and waited. They took him and his daughter-in-law and her children to a resettlement village in the lowlands. An old man was not much use to the cooperative, so he was set to minding children and drying tobacco. Younger men went to meetings; Blong sat at the back and said nothing. People still came to him at night to ask about weddings, debts and which spirits were angry, and he answered them quietly. From a man selling salt he heard which of the old officers had died in the camps, and said their names once, quietly, so the children would hear them. Blong lived out his life in the village under watch. When he died, the village found enough pipes for a qeej.

Blong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Night at the Caves. In the dry season of 1977 the family was hiding with other households in limestone caves in the hills between Luang Prabang and Vientiane. Blong slept near the mouth, because old men wake easily and he wanted to hear anyone coming. Soldiers came in the dark. He shouted the alarm and the families at the back fled through a second opening into the trees. Blong did not come out. His widow carried his burial clothes across the Mekong two years later, and in Ban Vinai the family laid them on the bier and played the qeej for three days. His grandsons still say his shout is the reason they are alive.

Blong 6 STARVED

A Grandfather's Share. In the cold season of 1979, in the Vang Vieng hills, the family's last rice was a few handfuls in a cloth. Blong told his daughter-in-law that old men need little food, and he poured his share into the children's bowls every evening. He spent the days telling the grandchildren the names of their ancestors, seven generations back, until they could say them without him. In January he did not wake. His sons buried him in his good jacket, and the eldest chanted the way back for his soul. When the family reached Thailand, the grandchildren were the ones who recited the ancestors' names for the camp clerk.

Blong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Dysentery in the Long Rains. In the wet season of 1977, the family sheltered in a ravine below Phou Bia while Blong waited for the patrols to thin before choosing a road. The stream they drank from was fouled by the camp above it. The children fell sick first, then Blong. He was seventy and could not hold down water. He spent his last lucid days drawing the route in the mud for his grandsons with a stick: the ridge, the salt spring, the ford. He died in September. The family followed his drawing the next dry season. In Ban Vinai a qeej player played for him, and his grandson redrew the route on paper for his own sons.

Blong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Old Road Was Mined. In the cold season of 1979 Blong led the family south by a trail he had walked in the 1960s, a ridge path that no patrol was supposed to know. Two days from the river they found fresh cuttings across it, a sign that soldiers had been there. Blong went ahead alone to look. The mine was under the leaves at a bend he remembered. His grandsons heard the sound and found him, and then went back and found another way down through the bamboo, slower, as he had taught them. They crossed four nights later. In Sob Tuang camp the eldest grandson held the funeral rites with his grandfather's walking stick laid in his place.

Blong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

His Road Began at the River. Blong could not swim, and he would not let anyone tie him to a son. He held a float of bamboo with two grandsons, telling them stories in a low voice to keep them calm. In the strongest current the float turned over. The boys came up holding the bamboo; their grandfather did not. In Ban Vinai his eldest son chanted the showing-the-way song Blong had taught him, beginning from the middle of the Mekong, because that is where his father's road home now started.

Blong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

An Elder Goes Last. Blong stayed on the bank to see every family into the water, because an elder goes last. He was stepping into the shallows himself when soldiers fired from the dark behind them. He fell in the shallows. His son, already swimming with a child, heard him call out once, the word for go. They went. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral through three nights, and every family he had seen into the river came to sit by the drum.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Cheng



Soldier; on Side B, SGU radio operator. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Cheng 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

A Stone at Arlington. Cheng spent four years in Ban Vinai and reached Minneapolis in 1980. He ran a stamping press at a plant in Northeast Minneapolis and studied English in a church basement. He woke shouting some nights, and his children learned not to touch him when he slept. His eldest son left high school and drifted for years; his daughter finished law school and represents tenants in court. In May 1997 Cheng rode overnight to Washington with other veterans for the dedication of a stone at Arlington, the first time the U.S. recognised the secret army on its own ground. In 2000 Congress waived the English requirement for SGU veterans, and he became a citizen soon after. In 2008 he went back to Laos and found the hill where his unit had camped. He hosts the clan New Year in his garage.

Cheng 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Repair Shop. Cheng spent a year in Ban Vinai and reached Minneapolis in February 1980. He washed dishes for $3.10 an hour, then repaired televisions for a shop owner amazed that a refugee knew circuits. By 1988 he had his own repair shop, with a back room where old soldiers drank tea. On weekends he read the news in Hmong on a community radio hour for elders who could not read English. His daughter became an electrical engineer. His son dropped out of college, worked in the shop for ten years, and now runs a phone repair business from it. Cheng's wife never learned English, and the grandchildren barely speak Hmong; Sunday dinners are quiet. In 2015 he went back to Laos once, as a tourist, and did not try to see Long Tieng. In July 2026 he enrolled for Minnesota's SGU veteran certificate and brought his old radio codebook to show the clerk.

Cheng 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Born in the Forest. Cheng went back into the forest around Phou Bia with the Chao Fa. He fought through the offensives of 1977 and 1978 and stayed on after most fighters had crossed to Thailand. He married in the forest, and his children were born there and never saw a school or a clinic. They moved camp whenever soldiers came near. Cheng died of fever in the late 1990s. His grandchildren are still among the families hiding around the mountain. In 2025 human-rights groups were still reporting attacks on them, which the government denies.

Cheng 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Released in the Eighties. Cheng fired his last cartridge on the trail and was taken alive. The soldiers knew a fighter when they saw one. He was sent to Camp 05 near Muang Xamteu with other men who had served with the Americans. For years he cut logs, repaired roads and dug irrigation ditches, and he wrote confessions that were never judged good enough. When rice was cut, the men shared what they had. He kept a spoon he had carved from a shell casing. Family visits were refused. In 1984 the government said the re-education centres had closed, but Cheng was held longer, and he was released in the late 1980s. He went home to his wife, who had waited, and farmed under watch until he died.

Cheng 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Rear of the Line. In the cold season of 1978 the group came down from the hills toward the Vang Vieng road, more than two hundred people in a single file. Cheng walked last with his old carbine, because he was the one who had fought. At a stream crossing a patrol fired on the tail of the line. Cheng fired back from the rocks until the women and children were over the ridge, and then the firing stopped. His brother went back that night and could not find him. In Ban Vinai the family held the funeral without his body. His son keeps a single cartridge case his brother picked up at the stream, on the shelf beside the New Year altar.

Cheng 6 — STARVED

Too Weak to Carry the Rifle. For two years after 1975 Cheng fought and hid in the forest north of Vang Vieng, and for two years the family ate what the forest gave. In the hot season of 1979 they started for the river. Cheng, who had once carried a radio, a rifle and a wounded friend down a mountain, could not carry his own pack. He walked until his knees gave way on the fourth day and asked his brother to take the family on. They left rice and water by him. They reached Ban Vinai a month later, and his brother told the story at every New Year afterward, always ending with the same words: he did not ask us to stay.

Cheng 7 — DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever After the Offensive. Cheng survived the 1977 fighting around Phou Bia without a wound, and the family thought him lucky. In the rains that followed they hid in a valley where the mosquitoes never stopped. He took the fever in July, shook with it for a week, seemed to recover, and then took it again. The pills he had saved from the army were long gone. He died in a lean-to of banana leaves while his wife held water to his mouth. His brother and two other veterans played no qeej, for fear of the sound, but sang the showing-the-way chant together under their breath. Two years later his wife carried his army photograph to Thailand.

Cheng 8 — KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

He Knew the Patrols. In the cold season of 1979 Cheng led the family south toward the river by the timetable he had worked out from months of watching the patrols. He knew when they slept and which trails they used. What he did not know was that the soldiers had mined a footpath the week before. He stepped off the path to let his children pass, and the mine was there. His wife took the children on, because he had told her a hundred times never to stop. They reached Ban Vinai a month later. In the camp a qeej player led his funeral with only his hat on the bier. In Minneapolis, years later, his wife still cooked his favourite dish every New Year.

Cheng 9 — DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

He Let Go of the Float. Cheng had never learned to swim. He held the back of the bamboo float with both hands while his brother pulled from the front. Halfway across, a neighbour's float came apart beside them, and her grandmother went under. Cheng let go to catch her, pushed her onto the bamboo beside his children, and could not reach the float again in the dark current. His brother dived for him twice. The float came ashore on the Thai sandbars. In Ban Vinai the old woman sat beside his widow through the whole funeral.

Cheng 10 — SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last Man on the Bank. Cheng had taken the rear, as he always did, watching the trail while the others went down into the water. The soldiers came along the bank with a light. Cheng stood in the open at the water's edge and fired back, and they shot him there. His last act was to push his son's hand off his shirt and into his brother's. The floats drifted out into the dark and reached Thailand. In Ban Vinai his son, who was six, wore his father's army belt at the funeral.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Kong



Doctor; on Side B, Medic trained at Sam Thong. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Kong 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Night Shift Nurse. Kong reached Nong Khai camp in 1975 and worked unpaid at the clinic, cleaning wounds and helping women in labour as he had at Sam Thong. In 1976 a church sponsored the family to St. Paul. His training counted for nothing there. He took a nursing-assistant course and worked nights at a nursing home for a few dollars an hour, studying English on the bus. At forty he passed his nursing exams on the third try, and for twenty years Hmong families asked for him at the hospital. His eldest son opened a grocery store on the East Side. His second son never settled after high school and fought depression for years before finding work as a welder. His daughter became a social worker. In retirement Kong checks blood pressure at clan gatherings and visited the hill where Sam Thong hospital once stood.

Kong 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Clinic Behind the Fence. Kong crossed in 1978 and spent fourteen years in Ban Vinai, working as a medic in the camp's health services as he had in the wards at Sam Thong. He delivered babies, and his own children grew up there, learning to read in the camp school. When the camp closed he came to a Minneapolis suburb at forty-five, too old to start again in medicine. He drove a delivery van. His children arrived as teenagers: his eldest daughter finished high school at twenty, went to college, and teaches English to new immigrants; his son, who could not catch up, works in a meatpacking plant and supports his own family. On weekends Kong visited old soldiers with his blood-pressure cuff. In 2023 he volunteered for the SGU wellness program, sitting with veterans who had never spoken of their nightmares.

Kong 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Five Years of Seminar. Kong was arrested in 1976 because he had treated soldiers, and sent to a re-education camp. For five years he cleared land and built roads, and he treated fellow prisoners with whatever grew near the camp. When he was released in 1981 he was watched too closely to flee. The district put him to work in a small dispensary. He married again, raised children who went to school in Lao, and never crossed. In 2009 a nephew from Minnesota found him, and they sat a whole afternoon together, saying little.

Kong 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Medicine in the Seminar. Kong was caught on the trail kneeling beside a wounded man. The soldiers knew he was a doctor who had treated soldiers, and he was sent to Camp 04 near Muang Et. In the camp he worked on the roads like everyone else, but at night he treated other prisoners in secret, boiling bark and setting bones with bamboo splints. When a guard brought him a sick child, he treated the child too, and after that a little medicine came to him. He gave most of it away. Rice was short, and his own health went slowly. In the third rainy season he fell ill with dysentery and died. The men he had treated buried him and said his name for years afterward.

Kong 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Wounded at the Stream. In the hot season of 1978 Kong was kneeling at a stream in the Vang Vieng hills, washing a shrapnel wound in a girl's leg, when a patrol came around the bend. The families foraging upstream scattered into the bamboo. Kong put himself between the soldiers and the girl. The girl was carried off by her uncle and lived; Kong did not. That evening the families gathered at the new camp and could not play the qeej, so his wife sang a kwv txhiaj for him in a whisper. The girl went to Ban Vinai, then to Fresno, and has worked for forty years as a medical interpreter.

Kong 6 STARVED

He Ate Last. In the hills above the Nam Ngum in the winter of 1978, Kong measured the family's food as he had once measured doses at Sam Thong: so much for the children, so much for the nursing mother, so much for the sick. He measured himself last and least. By February he could not walk to the stream. He knew what was happening to his body and said so plainly to his wife, so she would not be frightened. He died in March. She carried his notes to Ban Vinai, where a txiv neeb called her children's souls back from fear. His granddaughter became a nutritionist in Wisconsin.

Kong 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

The Sickness in the Camp. In the rains of 1976 more than a hundred people were hiding in a valley below Phou Bia, and the dysentery came through them like a fire. Kong had no medicine left, only what he knew: boil the water, keep the sick apart, give salt and rice water by the spoonful. He went from shelter to shelter for three weeks, sleeping in snatches, and then he fell sick himself. He died in early August. Most of the children he had nursed lived. A txiv neeb from another clan led his funeral, and families who had never been his relatives played the qeej for him through the night, which no one in the valley had dared to do for months.

Kong 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Last Patient on the Path. In the hot season of 1979 Kong's group walked toward the plain near Vientiane behind a guide who knew the paddy paths. A child ahead of Kong stumbled off the line and screamed; nothing happened, but the guide shouted at everyone to stand still. Kong went forward to look at the child's ankle, because that was what he did. The mine was under his foot. The guide would not let anyone go to him. They left him where he lay with his canvas bag beside him, and his nephew carried his medic's manual the rest of the way. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral with the bag on the bier. His nephew, a nurse in Minnesota, still has the manual, with the dust of that path in its spine.

Kong 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

He Held Up the Bag. Kong could not swim. He held the edge of an inner tube with one hand and his medical bag above the water with the other, because the bag was everything he could still do for people. When a wave from somewhere upstream rocked the tube, he let go of the tube, not the bag. His nephew found the bag floating and pulled it in, and searched the dark water until Kong's wife made him stop. In Ban Vinai the family held his funeral with the bag on the bier.

Kong 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

He Tested the Current. Kong had insisted on going into the water first, holding the rope, to test the current before the children came in. He was waist deep and turning to wave them in when soldiers on the bank fired. He was shot where he stood, waist deep, and the families scattered back into the reeds. They crossed two nights later, upstream. In Ban Vinai his widow sewed the night into a story cloth, a man in the river with his arm raised. She never sold it.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Lee



Medicine Woman; on Side B, Herbalist. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Lee 1 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Herbs on a Windowsill. Lee reached Ban Vinai in 1976 with a bag of dried roots and cuttings wrapped in wet bark. She planted them behind her shelter and treated fevers and new mothers alongside the camp clinic while the family waited three years for a sponsor. In 1979 a Catholic parish brought them to Providence, Rhode Island. Her son swept a jewellery factory floor; Lee packed eggs at a farm outside the city and learned enough English in a church basement class to ride the bus. Nothing she knew survived a New England winter, so she kept pots on every windowsill. Her granddaughter became a pharmacist; one grandson left high school and drifted for years before he trained as a welder. In old age Lee went back to Laos once, in 2005, to gather seed from the hills, and came home with nothing the border would let through.

Lee 2 — CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

The Soup for New Mothers. Lee and her son's family crossed in 1979 and spent a year in Ban Vinai, where her granddaughter started school in a bamboo classroom. In 1980 a Lutheran congregation sponsored them to the Detroit area. Her son worked a loading dock and studied English at night; Lee minded the children through a winter that frightened all of them. She turned the narrow backyard into a garden. Soon, when a Hmong baby was born anywhere in Michigan, someone drove to Lee's house for the herbs that go in the month-long postpartum chicken soup. Her granddaughter became a labour-and-delivery nurse and brought her colleagues to meet her. Her son never fully recovered from the war and drank for years. Lee lived to ninety, still giving advice by telephone.

Lee 3 — STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Letters on Cassette. When the escape failed, Lee went back toward home. Her family was moved to a lowland village under government watch and made to farm in common. She treated neighbours with her herbs, quietly, because healers who also called spirits drew attention. Her children who had crossed earlier sent cassette tapes from America, and she recorded answers on the same tapes: news of births, which plants were flowering, which relatives had died. She never left Laos. A grandson from Sacramento visited in the late 1990s and found her still gathering roots on the hillside.

Lee 4 — TAKEN PRISONER

Bark Under the Bunk. When the soldiers took Lee on the trail, someone told them she had nursed wounded fighters, so she was not sent to a village. She was marched north to a numbered camp in Houaphan. The prisoners cut logs and dug irrigation ditches, and the rice was thin. Lee scrounged as she always had. She picked leaves along the work paths, dried them under her bunk, and brewed them at night for men with fever or the flux. A guard saw her once and said nothing. In 1989 she was among those released from Houaphan. She walked into her daughter's lowland village with a cloth bag of seeds and roots, and spent her last years treating neighbours for coughs and burns.

Lee 5 — KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Shells at Phou Bia. In 1977 the families hiding below Phou Bia lived under constant pressure from Vietnamese and Lao troops. One afternoon Lee was pounding bark in a wooden mortar when the shells began to fall. She pushed the children toward the gully and went back for the toddler asleep in the shelter. She did not come back out. When the shelling stopped, her husband found her with the child unhurt beneath her. There was no time for a funeral; they left that night. In Ban Vinai a txiv neeb called the child's frightened soul back, and the family held Lee's rites with her clothes.

Lee 6 — STARVED

Her Share of Rice. By the cool season of 1977 the family's rice was carried in a single bamboo tube. Lee measured it out each evening in the Vang Vieng hills: a little for each grandchild, a little for the nursing mother, nothing for herself. She said the old did not need much. She ate boiled leaves and banana stem, and taught the children which shoots were safe. Her legs swelled, then her face. One morning she did not wake from beside the fire. Her son held the funeral in camp with a borrowed qeej, and every year at New Year her grandchildren put the first spoonful of rice in a bowl for her.

Lee 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Bark Tea for the Flux. In the rains of 1978 the family camped under bamboo above the Nam Xan, moving every few weeks. Half the camp had the bloody flux. Lee boiled bark over a smoky fire, carried the tea from shelter to shelter, and washed the sick with water hauled up from the stream. When the cramps took her too she kept dosing the others until she could not stand. She died on the fourth night, with rain drumming on the leaves. Her son buried her on the slope, and an old man spoke the showing-the-way words softly, without a qeej. Her daughter carried the blackened bark pot to Ban Vinai and kept it for the rest of her life.

Lee 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Old Field. In the dry season of 1977 the family hid in the Vang Vieng hills, and Lee went out to an abandoned field to dig for roots. The ground there was pocked with old craters, grown over with grass. Her hoe struck something round and rusted, and it went off. Her son found her at the edge of the clearing with the hoe beside her. They could not stay to mourn; he tied a thread to his wrist, burned a little incense and said her name to the hills. Years later in Minnesota her granddaughter read about the bombs still lying in Laotian fields, and every year she sent money to those who clear them.

Lee 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Tube Came Ashore. Lee crossed with a sealed bamboo tube of medicine tied around her waist, because she would not leave it behind. The current was stronger than anyone had said, and when the raft tipped in the dark she went under and did not come up. At first light her son walked the Thai bank and found only the tube, caught in tree roots, still sealed. In Ban Vinai the family held her funeral with her clothes in her place, and the dry bark inside it broke three fevers that winter.

Lee 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

The Last One on the Bank. Lee had stopped to pull a woman out of the mud, and so she was the last one still on the bank when the soldiers fired. Her son was already in the water with his daughter on his back and could not turn round. The current carried them over. From the Thai side they watched torches moving on the Lao bank until dawn. In Nong Khai camp a neighbour chanted the words that show the soul its way, and her son tied a white string on his daughter's wrist.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Bao



Tailor; on Side B, Tailor of warm clothes. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Bao 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Cloths for Sale. In Ban Vinai, Bao and other women began sewing a new kind of paj ntaub: story cloths, with soldiers, burning villages and people wading the Mekong in tiny stitches. Traders and relief workers bought them, and the money paid for meat and soap during the four years the family waited. In 1981 they were resettled in La Crosse, Wisconsin. Her husband worked nights cleaning a hospital; Bao took in alterations at her kitchen table, then opened a small shop. Her eldest daughter finished college and became a lawyer; her second son left school at sixteen and took years to find his way. Bao sewed every grandchild's New Year clothes. In 2019 she went to the dedication of the Hmong-Lao veterans memorial at Veterans Freedom Park, where her brother's name was read.

Bao 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Quilts for a Michigan Winter. Bao reached Ban Vinai in 1978 and spent a year there sewing for families who had walked out in rags. In 1979 a church sponsored them to Michigan. Nobody had warned them about the winter. Volunteers brought donated coats; Bao took the extras apart and resewed them to fit Hmong children. She worked in a hotel laundry and went to English class on Saturdays. Within a few years she was quilting for the neighbourhood from thrift-store fabric, and later sold quilts with paj ntaub borders at craft fairs. Of her five children, one became a social worker and one an auto engineer; one son was in a gang as a teenager and later spoke at schools about leaving it. Her grandchildren still sleep under her quilts.

Bao 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Seven Years Near Phou Bia. Turned back before the river, Bao's family joined others hiding in the forests around Phou Bia. They moved camp often, farmed small hidden plots and lost people to hunger and to the attacks of 1977 and 1978. Bao cut up her good clothes for children's shirts. In 1982 a guide led her group to the Mekong and they crossed on rafts. In Ban Vinai she sewed story cloths for sale like the other women, but hers showed the forest, not the river. She reached Wisconsin in 1987.

Bao 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Patches for the Plain. The soldiers who caught Bao on the trail took her sewing bundle and then, after looking through it, gave it back. She was sent with other captured civilians to the Plain of Jars and placed in a farming cooperative under government control. Cloth was scarce, so the cooperative made her its tailor. She patched work shirts, cut down old army trousers for children, and sewed cadre jackets when an official needed one for a meeting. She was paid in rice and was watched like everyone else. She married a widower there and raised his children with her own. She never left Laos. When New Year was allowed she still stitched the old patterns into collars, small, where nobody would think to look.

Bao 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Ambush Near the Road. In the cool season of 1976 Bao's group had to cross Route 13, where troops were hunting for the men who ambushed convoys. They waited in the elephant grass until dark, then went over in small bunches. Shots came out of the trees on the far side. Bao was carrying her sewing bundle and the youngest on her hip; the child was pulled clear, and she was not. Her husband led the family on that night. In Ban Vinai they held her funeral with a set of her clothes while a qeej played. Her eldest daughter kept the bundle of half-cut collars, and sewed one into every New Year outfit after that.

Bao 6 STARVED

Cloth for Rice. In the spring of 1978 Bao's family hid in the hills west of Vang Vieng, and the rice was gone. Bao did what she could: at night she walked down to the Lao farms with her paj ntaub folded in a cloth and traded a collar or a skirt panel for a basket of rice, the work of a year for a week of meals. When the last panel was gone she traded her silver, and then there was nothing. She filled the children's bowls first and said she had eaten while cooking. She died in the hot months before the rains, and her husband washed her and dressed her in the one skirt she had refused to sell. Her eldest daughter later sewed the family's story cloth with a mother at a Lao door, a bundle in her arms.

Bao 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Sewing in the Fever. In the rains of 1977 Bao's family sheltered under banana leaves in the Vang Vieng hills, and dysentery went through the camp. Bao nursed the children with rice water and kept sewing between their fits, cutting down an army blanket into jackets for the cold months she knew were coming. When the cramps took her she worked by feel, lying down. She finished the last jacket two days before she died. Her sister washed her and dressed her in her best paj ntaub, and an old man chanted the showing-the-way softly, without a qeej. Every child in the group wore one of those jackets through the winter in the hills, and her daughter kept hers folded in a chest in Michigan for fifty years.

Bao 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

A Hut by the Road. In the cold season of 1979 Bao's family sheltered for a night in an empty hut at the edge of a lowland village, a day's walk from the river. The people had fled, and the soldiers who came after them had left something behind. Bao went in first, to spread the children's bedding, and lifted a mat that had been laid over the floor. The blast took her and spared the children, who were still outside with their father. There was no time for more than a few words and a bowl of rice left on the step. In Ban Nam Yao camp her husband held the rites with her clothes. Their daughter still wears a jacket Bao cut down from an army blanket on that walk.

Bao 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

The Dry Bundle. Bao tied the children's winter clothes in a plastic sheet on her head and swam behind the raft with one hand on it. Midway an eddy spun the raft and tore her grip away. Her son called for her across the black water until the others made him stop. Two days later Thai villagers found the bundle in the shallows downstream, the clothes inside still dry, and a camp worker brought it to Ban Vinai. Her sister wore Bao's own jacket from it at the funeral.

Bao 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

A Jacket Sewn Too Big. Bao stayed on the bank to tie the last child onto the raft, in a jacket she had sewn too big so it would last. The soldiers came out of the trees and fired as the raft pushed off, and she dropped in the shallows. Her husband held the raft and the children and kicked for Thailand. They reached the far bank without her. At the funeral in Nong Khai camp the qeej played all night, and the boy wore that jacket through two winters until it fit him.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Ka



Singer; on Side B, Kwv txhiaj singer. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Ka 1 · CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

Songs on Tape. Ka was known in Ban Vinai for her kwv txhiaj, the long sung poems about orphans, lost homes and courting. In her four years there she sang at New Year, and someone recorded her on a borrowed cassette player; copies reached America before she did. In 1980 her family was resettled in Sacramento. She worked in a garment shop, then a school cafeteria, and studied English at an adult school. Her husband, a former soldier, could find only seasonal farm work and grew quiet. Of their children, one became a public-health nurse and another a Sacramento police officer; one daughter married at sixteen and finished school later as an adult. Ka kept singing at weddings and New Year, and in old age a granddaughter put her songs online so relatives in Laos and Minnesota could hear them.

Ka 2 · CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Night Songs in Ontario. On the walk Ka sang low at night so the children would sleep. In Ban Vinai she sang for the sick and the grieving and married a young widower. When resettlement came in 1979 the couple chose Canada, where only a few Hmong families were being settled. A church in southern Ontario sponsored them; she worked on a factory line for twenty years and learned English on the job. Because she was one of the few singers in the province, families phoned her to sing at weddings and New Year. Her stepson became a high-school teacher; her own daughter studied engineering; her youngest son, lonely as the only Hmong boy in his class, left home young and came back years later. In retirement Ka taught kwv txhiaj to teenage girls, explaining each old word before they sang it back.

Ka 3 · STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Still in Laos. Ka's group was turned back and she returned to the hills, then to a resettlement village where the family was registered and watched. She married there and raised six children. She sang at New Year when it was allowed, but never the songs about the war. Her cousins in America sent money and, after 2000, visited. Ka never crossed and never wanted to by then. She still lives in Laos, and young relatives from Wisconsin record her singing on their phones when they visit.

Ka 4 · TAKEN PRISONER

A Song Across the River. Ka was caught on the trail and sent with other captured civilians to a resettlement village near Xieng Khouang town. She farmed in common and kept her voice low. The officials liked songs about work and the new country, and she learned a few. At night, for the women, she sang the old ones. She married there and had a son. In the late 1980s her husband's brother came with a guide, and the family left in the rains. They walked by night because escapees were caught or shot on those routes. They crossed the Mekong holding on to bamboo. In Ban Vinai Ka sang at New Year, and the family was later resettled in the United States, where she sang at weddings.

Ka 5 · KILLED BY SOLDIERS

Ambush at the Stream. In the dry season of 1978 Ka went out with the other young women to gather leaves and dig cassava along a stream below Phou Bia. They worked quietly, because soldiers watched the water. Someone stepped on a dry branch. The firing came from across the stream, and the women scattered into the bamboo. Ka did not come back. Her mother and sister found her the next day and buried her where she lay. There was no qeej, only her mother's voice saying the showing-the-way words. Her sister sang Ka's songs to herself for the rest of the walk, so as not to forget them.

Ka 6 · STARVED

The Burned Rice. In 1977 Ka's family farmed a hidden plot in the Vang Vieng hills. Just before harvest the soldiers found it and burned the standing rice. For the rest of the year they lived on what the forest gave: shoots, bitter leaves, small fish from the streams. Ka sang the children to sleep so they would not cry with hunger. Her husband came back from foraging one evening to find her too weak to lift her head. She died that week. With no qeej player in the group, her husband chanted what he remembered. Her son, a teacher in Fresno, still hums the songs she sang over those empty bowls.

Ka 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever Under the Mountain. In the rains of 1978 Ka's family hid in bamboo shelters on the slopes below Phou Bia. Mosquitoes whined all night. Ka caught a fever that came and went every two days; she sang to the children through the good days and shook under every blanket on the bad ones. There was no medicine, only bark tea. She died in the ninth week, so thin her silver rings slid off her fingers. Her husband buried her on a slope facing east, and an uncle chanted the showing-the-way. Her daughter kept the rings and wore them on a string around her neck through the camp years.

Ka 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Ground Under the Fire. In early 1977 Ka's family camped by an old field near the plain, where the hills drop toward Vientiane. It was cold at night, and Ka scraped a hollow in the earth and built a fire for her mother and sister. She did not know that a small bomb from the war lay buried just beneath it. When the heat reached it, it went off. Her sister was burned but lived. They buried Ka at the edge of the field, and her mother wept the old mourning song. Years later, in Michigan, her sister would not let her grandchildren build a campfire without first digging the ground by hand.

Ka 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Singing Out Over the Water. Ka could swim a little, so she went in last, to watch the children ahead. The river was high and brown and full of drifting wood. Halfway over she called to them in her singing voice, the way she gathered them at night, and then her voice stopped. Thai fishermen found her downstream two days later and buried her on their bank. Her husband was allowed to visit the grave once, and sang over it the only song he knew.

Ka 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Last Down the Bank. Ka was the last down the bank, carrying the pot and the blanket, when a flashlight found her. Soldiers fired from the path above and she fell among the reeds. She had told the others to go first, and they had. Her husband turned back; their son, clinging to the float, screamed for him, and he came. In Ban Vinai he would not let anyone say her name for a year. Then at New Year he asked a woman from their village to sing Ka's songs, and listened with his eyes closed.

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ENDINGS 1 TO 10

Pa



Shaman; on Side B, Shaman, soul caller. Endings 1 to 10, the same on either side of the card. Find the number in the table on page 3, then read it here.

Pa 1 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 1–10

The Gong in Detroit. Pa crossed in 1978 with her shaman's tools wrapped in a blanket: the rattle-ring, the finger bells and the split horns. In Ban Vinai she performed ua neeb for families frightened by the crossing while they all waited for sponsors. In 1979 her family was resettled near Detroit. Her son worked in a parts plant; Pa learned a little English and set up her altar in a rented living room. On weekends families drove from across Michigan for her, the gong sounding through thin walls; after one complaint she warned the neighbours in advance. Her son became a doctor and sometimes sent patients' families to her; her daughter converted to Christianity, and for years they barely spoke. In 2008 Pa returned to Laos to perform rites at her parents' graves, then came home to her grandchildren.

Pa 2 CROSSED THE MEKONG · FORTUNE 11–20

Fourteen Years of Funerals. Pa reached Ban Vinai in 1979 and stayed until it closed in the early 1990s. In a camp of tens of thousands she called back souls frightened loose by the war and the river, and led rites for those who had died on the way, often without bodies. Her children went to the camp schools, learned some Thai and English, and waited. In 1993 the family flew to Sacramento. Pa was over sixty and never worked outside the home; her son started on an assembly line at $5 an hour. She performed hu plig in his garage and led funerals at the funeral homes Hmong families rented. One grandson became a social worker; another struggled in school and was later in prison, and she called his soul each time he came home. When she died in 2011, three people she had trained led her funeral.

Pa 3 STILL IN LAOS WHEN THE GAME ENDS

Under Phou Bia. When the crossing failed, Pa went back into the forest with the Chao Fa families near Phou Bia. For years she was their shaman, performing rites quietly because the gong could carry. Many in her group crossed to Thailand after the offensives of 1977 and 1978; Pa would not leave the sick. Relatives in America heard of her through travellers into the 1990s, then nothing. Groups of Hmong were still reported hiding in that jungle in 2006 and in 2025. Her family does not know if she lived among them.

Pa 4 TAKEN PRISONER

Finger Bells in a Rice Sack. Pa was caught on the trail and sent with other captured families to a resettlement village near Xieng Khouang town. Officials there called her rites superstition and forbade the gong. Pa kept her finger bells wrapped in a rice sack and did her healing at night, with the door shut and the rattle muffled in cloth. Neighbours came to her quietly when a child would not stop crying. In the mid 1980s her son found a guide. Pa left with the bells and her shaman's horn and walked by night, because escapees were often caught on that route. They crossed the Mekong in the dark. In Ban Vinai she set up her altar again, and later called souls in a garage in California.

Pa 5 KILLED BY SOLDIERS

The Cave at Night. In the cool season of 1977 Pa's family sheltered with others in a cave in the limestone hills between Vang Vieng and the Nam Ngum. They had left their rooster behind so its crowing would not give them away. Soldiers attacked the cave in the night. Pa was at the back with the sick, and she would not leave them. When it was over her son found her beside her shaman's bench, her finger bells still in her hand. With no other shaman in the group, an old man said the showing-the-way words over incense. Her son carried her tools to Thailand wrapped in a blanket and never let them out of his house.

Pa 6 STARVED

Rice for the Grandchildren. In the cool season of 1977 Pa's family hid in the hills near Vang Vieng with almost nothing left. Pa had performed rites for the sick in exchange for rice all her life, and now there was no rice to give. She made the grandchildren eat first and told them the spirits would feed her. She ate leaves and drank hot water. Her son saw her shrinking and said nothing. She died in her sleep before the new year. A neighbour said the showing-the-way. Her son carried her tools to Ban Vinai, and in his house in Detroit the grandchildren still set out rice for her at New Year.

Pa 7 DIED OF SICKNESS

Fever in the Wet Season. In the rains of 1978 Pa's group sheltered under bark roofs on the wooded slopes below Phou Bia. Fever went through the camp. Pa called soul after soul, sitting before her makeshift altar through the night, and when the shaking fever took her too she kept calling until she could not lift the rattle. She died before dawn. With no other shaman among them, her daughter, who had followed her to every funeral as a girl, said as much of the showing-the-way as she knew. In the camp at Ban Vinai a shaman from her clan held the proper rites, and her daughter remembered the words she had not.

Pa 8 KILLED BY A BOMB OR A MINE

The Shortcut. In the cold season of 1979 Pa's group followed a guide along a footpath toward the Mekong, and Pa, slow with age, fell behind. A young man took her a shorter way across a dry streambed to catch the others up. The guide had not brought them that way for a reason. The mine took Pa and spared the young man, who carried her finger bells to the river. Her son said her name on the path and left a cup of rice and a stick of incense. In Sob Tuang camp another shaman led her rites with a rooster and a set of her clothes, and her son later told his own children that she had shown the dead the way for forty years.

Pa 9 DROWNED IN THE MEKONG

Back Onto the Float. Pa crossed on a moonlit night, sharing a float of four bamboo poles with her daughter. Halfway over, the girl's grip failed and she slid off. Pa let go to reach her, pushed her back onto the float, and could not catch it again in the current. The daughter reached the Thai bank at first light. In Ban Vinai a shaman called the girl's frightened soul back with a rooster, and the family held Pa's funeral with her clothes and her finger bells.

Pa 10 SHOT TRYING TO CROSS

Calling the Children First. At every crossing point Pa stopped at the water's edge to call the children's souls, so none would stay behind on the Lao side afraid. She was doing it when the patrol saw her. They fired from the bank, and she fell in the mud with the rattle-ring in her hand. Her son dragged the children into the water. In Ban Vinai a shaman led her rites. Her son, who became a shaman in Wisconsin, begins every crossing of his own by calling the children first.

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